

As land becomes a political plinth major investors may be driven away, thanks to the Government's dithering over a relief and rehabilitation policy since 2005

■ By Nivedita Mukherjee

It happens only in India. One Mamata Banerjee, 40,000 furious protesters and a coalition of unnatural allies shut down a highway, hold a state to ransom and drive out an iconic investor like Ratan Tata and investments worth Rs 1,500 crore. It didn't matter to the politicians that this also meant loss of 10,000 jobs that would have been created. Ranging from the Jamat-e-Islami to Samajwadi Party to CPI-M and activists like Medha Patkar, many have forged a common cause in question-

ing the allotment of farm land to Tatas. West Bengal Governor Gopalkrishna Gandhi has met Trinamool Congress representatives thrice in a valiant attempt to forge a solution, but with elections round the corner most leaders fear any political solution will suffer rhetorical attacks. The saving grace is that the Tatas yet call it only a "suspension" of operations leaving a window open for the politicians to come to their senses.

Sure, the theory is that investments lead to creation of jobs, generation of revenue and all round development. But politics is about the immediate not the future, not when the polls are

TATA BYE BYE?



SUBIR HALDAR

PROJECTS WHICH HAVE LAND(ED) IN TROUBLE

SINGUR
West Bengal
997 acre

TATA STEEL
Chhattisgarh
3,000 acre

TATA STEEL
Jharkhand
5,000 acre

TATA STEEL
Orissa
2,000 acre

POSCO STEEL
Orissa
4,000 acre

ARCELOR MITTAL
STEEL PLANT, Orissa
7,000 acre